

Multiculturalism and its impact on social cohesion

In recent decades there has been an accentuated prevalence of immigration taking place across the globe, a tendency which is perceived to drive down social cohesion due to the ethnic diversity it causes. In the absence of trust and solidarity, egalitarian redistribution becomes unfeasible, which negatively impacts the welfare state. Thus, many democratic countries are employing integrational policies such as multiculturalism in an attempt to tackle the challenges posed by immigration and to ensure social cohesion within diverse societies. In this essay, I am going to explore to what extent political multiculturalism could potentially mitigate levels of social segregation while arriving at the conclusion that overall multiculturalism is more likely to undermine social cohesion instead of fostering it. Additionally, I will also shed light on whether multiculturalism can be considered a feasible objective in the face of nationalism and why it tends to account for the emergence of parallel societies rather than a unified, cohesive one.

Multicultural politics places a strong emphasis on the “shared recognition of religious and cultural differences”, which is said (Holtug, 2021) to serve as the basis for social cohesion. Consequently, it is expected that a society that embraces such values is bound to treat immigrants equally and be more understanding of minorities, which in turn bolsters a sense of inclusion and loyalty to the political system among immigrant societies. Multicultural policies designed to promote cultural differences may include for example the establishment of separate schools, exemptions from the law, or providing political autonomy. For instance, there has been a multitude of exemptions pertaining to dress codes that allow people to wear turbans or hijabs, etc. By enacting such policies immigrants feel more accepted by the broader community, thus increasing levels of trust and solidarity. Additionally, the integration of minorities into different spheres of the receiving society, such as the educational system or the labour market, enables the facilitation of contact between different cultures, which can help abolish stereotypes and bridge divides through in-person interactions. For example, at the workplace colleagues are often required to engage in cooperative activities towards a common objective, within the framework of which individual differences become minimized, thus alleviating the boundaries between groups of diverse cultures. Ultimately, it is argued (Holtug, 2021; Wright, 2010) that such experiences can positively shape the general approach and attitudes towards members of ethnic minorities.

However, while multicultural politics may aim at enhancing social cohesion and equality, in practice it causes ethnic groups to become more isolated and self-sufficient, lacking the bonds that are essential for mutual respect and solidarity. The reason for this is that multicultural policies advocate for encouraging minorities to preserve or even strengthen their identification with their ethnic background. The establishment of separate educational institutions is a good case in point, by which they instill the impression that minorities are in fact different. As a result, there is more emphasis put on differences than on similarities between altering groups of ethnicities, thus inhibiting the cultivation of a common identity, which forms the foundation of trust and solidarity. Consequently, the ability to identify with the wider community of the host country is at stake, ultimately undermining social cohesion. Concurrently with the

reinforcement of ethnic identities arises the process of cultural fragmentation. As a consequence, differences become more polarized than ever, and hence cultures become less receptive to conflicting viewpoints, making it difficult to find common ground and establish a set of shared values. Thereby, this phenomenon further exacerbates the division and isolation between cultures. On the other hand, interactions between the general public and minorities are indeed likely to minimize prejudices and preconceptions. For instance, it was found (Bieber, 2018) that in contrast to smaller towns that have little to no contact with immigrants, residents of larger, multinational cities like London are more accustomed to exposure to migrants and perceive them as less hostile or threatening. However, in most cases, multiculturalism fails to establish such convergence of the host population and the minorities due to policies promoting the maintenance of identification with one's ethnic background, based on which immigrant minorities do not feel the need for assimilation. This can be substantiated by studies (Holtug, 2021, p. 262) indicating that "levels of urban segregation are highest in countries that have stronger multicultural policies". Hence such incentives tend to account for the segregation and isolation of ethnic groups, ultimately impeding exposure to each other and missing out on opportunities that would bring people of diverse cultures together.

Multiculturalism also entails a two-faceted approach to inequality: one from the receiving society's perspective and one from the immigrants' or minorities' perspective. On the one hand, law-skilled immigrants are said (Holtug, 2021, p. 125) to impose an immense economic strain on the state, while getting access to "high minimum wages, social services and free health care". In other words, they are exploiting the welfare state to their advantage, which is likely to provoke a sense of injustice on behalf of the receiving community. Additionally, by virtue of the pushed agenda pertaining to multicultural policies, too much focus on cultural recognition could potentially suggest the idea that other more relevant political, economic, or social issues become neglected and overlooked. Furthermore, privileges or exemptions from the law that are guaranteed to immigrants but not to the mainstream population, can in some cases lead to perceptions of favouritism, which implies the fact that minorities receive preferential treatment, thus further aggravating feelings of inequality. In addition, in order to propagate ideologies and serve political interests, immigrants are often portrayed in a negative light through the media and political discourse, causing the emergence of overgeneralizations and stereotypes. Such negative media coverage, coupled with the injustice associated with immigration, is likely to inflict hostility and a sense of resentment towards minorities. As a result, the division between in and outgroup members of the nation becomes starker, essentially leading to the establishment of the terms "others" and "us versus them". Conversely, such perpetuated biases pose a wide range of inherent injustices that immigrants have to face. Oftentimes, ethnic minorities have difficulties integrating into the host society due to automatically being exposed to underlying discrimination. Consequently, they may encounter obstacles and have limited chances in the spheres of everyday life, ranging from educational, occupational, and economic opportunities. Similarly, unprivileged immigrants are frequently subjected to (Boufkhed, 2023) exploitation at the workplace and the denial of basic human rights including low wages, hazardous working conditions, and being forced to work long hours. Thus, not being treated equally as the majority can foster a sense of exclusion and simultaneously weaken the sense of belonging to a cohesive community. Hence, multiculturalism manifests itself in a feeling of injustice on both ends of the spectrum, which ultimately reduces trust and drives down social cohesion.

Along with multicultural policies that do not require cultural assimilation, social segregation can also occur as a response to such embedded discrimination and mistreatment of immigrants and ethnic minorities. Therefore, multiculturalism results in the emergence of parallel societies formed by distinct groups, often functioning completely independently of the host society. Parallel societies may include patterns of residential segregation, where people from similar backgrounds live in the same neighbourhood. Additionally, they tend to have their own networking systems, businesses, and educational institutions, while cultivating and preserving their traditions, religious practices, and cultural heritage. Ultimately, such implications of multiculturalism entail cultures becoming more distant rather than more cohesive. France serves as a good example (Magyar Nemzet, 2023) capturing the essence of parallel societies, where there has been an abundance of riots and violence taking place due to discrimination and law enforcement that disable the integration of immigrants into the host society, while showcasing the cohesion-disruptive nature of multiculturalism.

Furthermore, strong nationalistic views can also hinder the feasibility of multicultural policies, according to which multiculturalism clashes with the core values of nationhood (Wright, 2010). Arguably, with the increase of ethnic diversity, it becomes more challenging to maintain a sense of nation, which weakens the social cohesion of the imagined community and thus undermines loyalty to the state. Consequently, it is likely that states only approve of values that are congruent with theirs, thus insufficiently catering to the objectives of multiculturalism. Additionally, nationhood involves elements such as a native language, a shared history, an anthem, a flag, and other national symbols that cannot encompass every minority, which is again incompatible with the principles of multiculturalism.

After carefully assessing the way multicultural policies function in real-life contexts, it can be concluded that these concepts tend to be idealistic along with failing to consider the dynamics and interactions that are inherent in diverse societies, ultimately accounting for an unrealistic attempt at perfection. Thus, although multiculturalism may seek to increase equality and social cohesion, in reality, it exacerbates feelings of injustice and fuels tensions and social upheaval, while making ethnic groups more autonomous and polarized, depriving them of the ties necessary for unity and social cohesion.

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